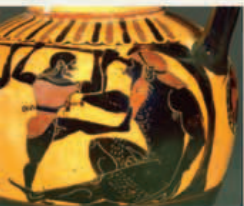


BEFORE

Ancient Greece was not a unified nation but a mosaic of around 150 city-states sharing a common language and religion; the two most important were Athens and Sparta.

A NATION OF CITY-STATES

After the destruction of the Mycenaean civilization (whose stories, including the *Odyssey*, were recorded by Homer), ancient Greece entered the Dark Ages, about which we know little. Cities and their surrounding land became independent units known as city-states (*polis*).



SCENE FROM THE ODYSSEY

THE HOPLITE REVOLUTION

The city-states relied on their armies for their protection. Increased trade in the 7th century BCE began a military and political revolution. The new rich could now afford their arms and supplied regiments of hoplites (armored infantry) alongside the aristocratic cavalry. The need to act collectively in warfare led to a new form of government based on the shared interests of a broader section of society.

Athens' first lawgiver was Draco (c. 624 BCE). His severe penalties were designed to stop the aristocrats from taking the law into their own hands. In 594 BCE military defeat by the city of Megara and growing social tensions led to the appointment of Solon as supreme *archon* (magistrate). Since rural impoverishment had caused an agrarian (farming) and military crisis in Athens, Solon's solution was to abolish slavery brought about by debt, free the peasantry from feudal servitude, and make wealth rather than birth the prerequisite of political office, thus reducing the power of the aristocracy.

To encourage good governance (*eunomia*), he created a council (*boule*) to prepare the weekly business of the

lot from each of the 10 tribes, which supplied the smaller 50-member group of council leaders (*Prytaneis*) to administer the daily affairs of government. Its composition was changed on a regular basis so that no one remained in power too long. Jury members for the courts were also chosen randomly to avoid corruption.

The 6,000-strong *ecclesia* convened weekly on the Pnyx, a site near the Acropolis, to vote on matters presented by the *Prytaneis* and elect the 10 generals (*strategoi*). Since Athens' defense could not be left to chance, these powerful officials, who controlled the army and the navy, could be reelected.

The effect of all these reforms was to reduce the powers of the aristocracy further while creating a united body

Birthplace of democracy

The Acropolis ("high city") of Athens was its spiritual center. The Parthenon (finished in 431 BCE), the temple at the top of the Acropolis dedicated to the goddess Athena, was built by the Athenian general Pericles following the defeat of the Persians, with money from the Delian League, as a symbol of Athens' glory.

"... a man who takes no interest in politics... has no business here at all..."

PERICLES, 495–429 BCE

The Birth of Democracy

The oldest and most stable democracy in ancient Greece developed in Athens, evolving constitutionally through monarchy, aristocracy, and tyranny before arriving at the principle of equality for all citizens. However, as in other Greek *polis*, women, slaves, and foreigners were excluded from participating.

citizen's assembly (*ecclesia*), and a popular court of appeal (*heliaia*) for legal redress against abuses of power. Citizens were divided into four classes: aristocrat, "horseman," hoplite, and the poor (*thetes*), each of which elected 100 members to the council. Poor citizens could only vote at this stage.

In 560 BCE, the aristocrat Peisistratus took advantage of incessant internal feuding to seize power in a popular coup, initiating land reforms on behalf of the poor. It was against a backdrop of the increasingly harsh rule of his son that a progressive aristocrat called Cleisthenes overthrew this tyranny in 507 BCE, introducing the revolutionary reforms that would transform Athens into a formidable power and Greece's first true democracy.

DEMOCRACY From the ancient Greek words "*demos*," meaning "people," and "*kratos*," meaning "power."

of men loyal to Athens above all else. As a further safeguard, ostracism was introduced to banish any "dangerous" leaders from the city for 10 years.

Imperial power

With unity at home, Athens set about raising its profile abroad, investing in a powerful navy after its victory over the Persians at Marathon in 480 BCE, and acknowledging the growing importance of its oarsmen following an impressive naval victory over the

Persians at Salamis in 490 BCE. Increasing colonization, dominance of the

trade routes, the discovery of silver, and the creation in 477 BCE of the Delian League—an alliance with other city-states to protect themselves from future Persian invasions—made Athens the dominant power in Greece.

A brilliant orator called Pericles presided over a "Golden Age" of Athenian prosperity (451–429 BCE) and cultural preeminence. He consolidated the democratic "constitution" by compensating the poorer citizens for their time on jury service or attending the *ecclesia*, and limiting citizenship to those with two Athenian parents.

Democracy in Athens was suspended and quickly restored twice during the 5th century BCE. It was finally extinguished during the 2nd century BCE by an expanding Roman Empire.

Athens' democratic evolution

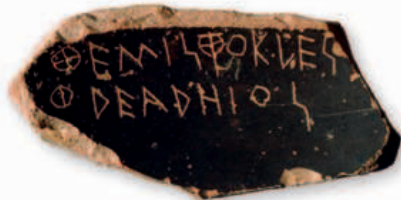
Cleisthenes created a future for Athens' citizens to match their potential. In place of *eunomia*, he promised *isonomia* (equality). To neutralize factional feuding, he tore up the old network of family and regional loyalties, redividing Athens into 139 voting districts (*demes*) arranged into 10 tribes (*phylae*) made up of citizens from each of the three regions—coast, interior, and city—in an elaborate system of checks and balances. Annual membership of an expanded council of 500 was chosen by



KLEROTERION



KLEPSHYDRA (WATER CLOCK)



OSTRAKON (VOTING TABLET)

Objects of democracy

The *kleroterion* was used to select jurors. Slots in the device (fragment shown) held volunteers' names, and black and white balls were dropped down a tube to select them. Water clocks were used to time the speeches in the Assemblies. Citizens inscribed the names of overly ambitious politicians that they wished to ostracize from the city on an *ostrakon*.

AFTER

It took a long time for the idea of democracy to become widely adopted; it was not until the mid-20th century that it became the most common form of government.



ROMAN VOTING

ROMAN DEMOCRACY

Republican government in ancient Rome was based on elected representatives (representative democracy) rather than Athenian-style direct democracy. Power was shared between the two

Consuls, the Senate (aristocracy), and the Plebs (commoners). Over time, the Plebeian Assembly became the dominant legislature.

AMERICAN GOVERNMENT

The architects of the first modern democracies in the US 298–99 >> and France 302–03 >>, modeled them on the Roman Republic with representation limited to the wealthier classes only. The Athenians thought that representative democracy was tilted in favor of wealthier candidates. During the campaign for the 2008 US presidential election, the main candidates raised over \$25 million each.

THE WORLD'S LARGEST DEMOCRACY

India's democracy governs a population of over a billion people.